THE MENSTRUAL CYCLE

For a few days each month, the lining of the uterus is shed and blood passes out through the vagina. The lining thickens again to prepare for the implantation of a fertilized egg. This is the menstrual cycle. It starts when the pituitary gland releases FSH (see opposite), which stimulates egg follicles in the ovary. The follicles secrete oestradiol, a form of oestrogen. This triggers the release of LH, which matures the egg and weakens the follicle wall, allowing the release of the mature egg (ovum). Whether the right or left ovary ovulates is entirely random. If fertilized, the embryo is implanted into the uterine wall, and signals its presence by releasing human chorionic gonadotropin (HCG), the hormone measured in pregnancy tests. This signal maintains the corpus luteum and enables it to continue producing progesterone. In the absence of a pregnancy and without HCG, the corpus luteum dies and progesterone levels fall. Progesterone withdrawal leads to menstrual bleeding and, as FSH levels rise, a new crop of follicles is formed – the cycle begins again.